DECODE YOUR ASSIGNMENT.

1. YOUR GOAL

By the end of this sheet you will have turned one assignment prompt into a short list of what you are being asked to do, what you must include, and what to do first. Allow about 20 minutes.

2. THE QUESTION



MABBIT'S SECOND LOOK

A prompt is a set of rules written by someone who already knows the answer to "what counts."

1. **Which words in this prompt tell me what to do, and which only describe the topic?**
2. **What is being assumed that I will be graded on but nobody wrote down?**
3. **Who decides what counts as "good" here, and where could I find out?**

3. HOW TO READ IT

WHONAH'S FIELD NOTES

Do this with a pen on the actual prompt before you write anything.

1. **Underline every verb.** These are your tasks.
2. **Circle every number or format rule.** Length, source count, citation style, file type, deadline.
3. **Box the words must, should, and may.** "Must" is required. "May" is up to you or up to them.
4. **Find the grading criteria.** Rubric, syllabus section, or ask. Write down where you found it.



Look for: verbs, numbers, and the words must, should, and may

4. WHAT THE TASK WORDS USUALLY ASK FOR

Instructors use these loosely, so treat this as a starting guess and confirm it.

TASK WORD	USUALLY ASKS YOU TO
Describe / summarize	Report what is there, accurately. No verdict needed.
Explain	Say how or why something works, using reasons, not just facts.
Analyze	Break it into parts and show how the parts relate or what they do.
Compare	Put two or more things side by side on stated criteria, then say what the comparison shows.
Argue / evaluate	Take a position and defend it with evidence. Name the strongest objection.
Reflect	Connect the material to your own experience or thinking, and say what changed.

5. WORKED EXAMPLE

Sample prompt invented for this worksheet. It is not from a real course.

> Write a 1,200-word paper that analyzes how one policy affected a community you choose. Use at least four scholarly sources. You should address multiple perspectives. Cite in APA.

- **Tasks:** "analyze" (break down how the policy worked on the community), "address multiple perspectives."
- **Hard rules:** 1,200 words, at least four scholarly sources, APA.
- **Fog:** "should" (required or just advised?), "multiple" (is two enough?), "scholarly" (do reports count?).
- **First move:** email one question: "Do government reports count as scholarly sources, and is two perspectives enough?"

6. YOUR TURN

GUIDED PRACTICE

1. ## PASTE OR COPY YOUR PROMPT.

   Use the exact words, not your summary.

   CHECK YOUR WORK
   If you paraphrased, go back. The fog lives in the original wording.

2. ## MARK IT UP.

   Underline verbs, circle numbers and format rules, box must, should and may.

   WORKED EXAMPLE
   In the sample: "analyzes" underlined; "1,200", "four", "APA" circled; "should" boxed.

   CHECK YOUR WORK
   Every line of the prompt should have at least one mark, or be pure topic.

3. ## WRITE YOUR TASK LIST.

   One line per task, one line per hard rule, one line per fog word.

   CHECK YOUR WORK
   You should have at least one fog word. If you found none, ask what "done" looks like.

4. ## PICK YOUR FIRST MOVE.

   A question to send, a source to find, or a paragraph to draft. Make it doable today.

TASKS:

HARD RULES:

FOG WORDS:

MY FIRST MOVE:

7. CHECK THE EVIDENCE

CLAIM
The rubric says "critical thinking" is worth 30%.

EVIDENCE
A percentage and a label.

NOT SHOWN
What critical thinking looks like in this course.

CLAIM
A classmate says the instructor likes "strong voice."

EVIDENCE
One person's impression.

NOT SHOWN
Anything from the instructor or the rubric.

Your call: What can you actually conclude about how this will be graded, and what would you ask to find out?

8. REVIEW AND NEXT STEPS

- Could someone else start this assignment from your task list?
- Which fog word could cost you the most points? Ask about that one first.
- Where is the grading criteria written down? Save a copy.
- Next: check the rest of the course rules with Read the Fine Print.

9. SOURCES

This worksheet cites no outside sources. The sample prompt is invented, and the task-word table is a general guide, not a standard.

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